not answer) Roger! I said, what day of the month is it?

ROGER (*Hardly pausing*): It is the fifteenth, my lord.

WESTON: The fifteenth! The fifteenth of March. **The Ides of March!** (*Looking at the paper again; in a horrified whisper*)'***Remember Caesar***'! (*Louder*) So they want to kill me, do they? They want to kill me? (*ROGER comes to the surface, surprised.*) That is what it is to be a judge over men (*all his pompousness is dissolving in agitation*) an instrument of justice. Sooner or later revenge lies await in the by-ways. And the juster a judge has been, the more fearless (*he waves the paper in the astonished ROGER's face*), so much greater will be the hate that pursues –

ROGER: What is it, my lord? What is it?

WESTON: My death warrant if I am not careful. What cases have we had lately? The treason affair – I refused to be bribed! (*The boast gives him a passing comfort.*) The piracy – both sides hate me for that. Or there was that **footpad** –

ROGER: Is it a threat, the paper? Where did it come from?

WESTON: It was in my pocket. Someone must have …. Yes, now I remember. A man brushed against me yesterday as I was leaving the courts. A small, evil-looking fellow, very shy.

ROGER: What does it say, the paper?

WESTON (*much too occupied with his own fate to attend to his secretary's curiosity*): Just at the door, it was, and he didn't wait for an apology. I remember. Well, I can only thank them for the warning. I may die before my time but it will not be to-day if I can help it. Go downstairs at once, Roger, and lock, bar and chain all the doors. And ask my wife to come to me at once. At once. Stop! Are there any strangers in the house? Work men or such?

ROGER: Only Joel the gardener, my lord; he is cleaning the windows on the landing. (*He indicates with his head that Joel is just outside.*)

WESTON: Send him away at once. Tell him to leave everything and go and lock the door behind him. And the windows – see that the windows, too, are closed.

WESTON (*facing the cupboard with a levelled pistol*): Come out! Come out! I say. (*There is silence.*) Drop your weapon and come out or I shall shoot you now. (*As there is still silence he forces himself to close in on the cupboard door, and standing to the side pulls it quickly open. It is empty. As soon as his relief abates he is ashamed, and hastily returns the pistol to its drawer.*)

(*Enter, bright and purposeful, LADY WESTON. A charming creature. One knows at a glance that she is an excellent housewife, but to the last one is never sure how much intelligence and sweet malice there lies behind her practical simplicity.*)

LADY WESTON (*looking back as she comes in*): I do wish that Joel wouldn't leave pails of water on the landing! What is it, Richard?

WESTON: My dear, your husband's life is in grave danger.

LADY WESTON: The last time it was in danger you had been eating **game pie**. What is it this time?

12th General_English_Unit_6_C_Supplementary.indd 198 07-12-2021 18:21:04